DIBURIM — SEFER VAYIKRA

Tzaraas, Distinction, and the Journey Back to Hashem

Parshas Tazria–Metzora

Before we begin, I want to share a question. In our home, we have a small deal. On nights when I learn with one of my Rabbanim, when I put my daughter Liba Esther to bed, she is allowed to ask a question that I will bring to Rav Channen. One night, she asked: "Tati, why do we have to go to Olam Haba?"

That was her question, almost word for word.

In our home, we are careful with how we speak. We do not say that a person dies. We say a person goes back to Hashem, goes to Shamayim, goes to Olam Haba. So what she was really asking was: why do we go back to Hashem?

We will return to this question. But it is not a separate question from the parsha. It is the parsha.

The Strange World of Tzaraas

Parshas Tazria–Metzora elaborates for us a concept we have only glimpsed before in the Torah — the concept of tzaraas. Until now, we have seen flashes of it: with Moshe Rabbeinu at the burning bush, with Pharaoh in his encounter with Sarah, and later most clearly with Miriam. But here, the Torah does not just reference it. It builds it. It gives it structure, process, halacha, and meaning.

Tzaraas is not a medical disease. It is not what the world calls leprosy. It is a spiritual affliction that manifests physically — a פְּנִימִיּוּת reality that breaks through into the external world. Usually, spirituality is hidden. A person can be misaligned internally and no one would ever know. Tzaraas changes that. Tzaraas reveals. It takes something internal and forces it outward.

The Causes of Tzaraas

So what causes tzaraas? The Gemara teaches:

עַל שִׁבְעָה דְּבָרִים נְגָעִים בָּאִים

"For seven matters, afflictions come" (Talmud Bavli, Arachin 16a)

Among them: lashon hara, arrogance, theft, and stinginess — tzarut ayin. The most well-known is lashon hara. Chazal connect the word metzora to מוֹצִיא שֵׁם רַע — motzi shem ra — one who brings out a bad name.

But when we step back, a deeper pattern emerges. These are not random sins. They share a common root: misalignment. A failure to distinguish properly. A breakdown in boundaries. Take lashon hara. There is a halachic distinction: speaking negatively about a fellow Jew is strictly forbidden, while the halachic framework regarding a non-Jew is different. This does not mean it is permitted to speak negatively. But it does mean not everything is the same. If a person blurs that distinction — if they treat all categories equally without nuance — they are no longer aligned with Torah reality.

A Foundational Source: Fish and Meat

Before we build further, we can anchor this idea of misalignment in a sugya. The Gemara in Pesachim 76b records:

מָר בַּר רַב אָשֵׁי אָמַר: אֲפִילּוּ בְּמִילְחָא נָמֵי אֲסוּרָה, מִשּׁוּם דְּקַשְׁיָא לְרֵיחָא וּלְדָבָר אַחֵר

"Mar bar Rav Ashi said: Even with salt it is forbidden, because it is harmful to the smell and to something else."

On the words לְדָבָר אַחֵר — "to something else" — Rashi comments in a single word: צָרַעַת. Tzaraas.

That is striking. What does tzaraas have to do with fish and meat? Unless we understand something deeper. Fish and meat can feel similar. There are fish that are called "meaty." They cook similarly. They can look similar. But they are not the same. And the Torah requires that we maintain that distinction. If a person says they are basically the same, so I will treat them the same — that is not just a practical mistake. That is a collapse of categories. And when categories collapse, confusion enters. And when confusion enters, it does not stay abstract. It manifests.

Three Levels, One Message

With that foundation, the structure of the parsha becomes clear. The Torah presents tzaraas in a specific order: body first, then clothing, then house. That is the halachic order — from the most severe to the least. But if we look at it through the lens of personal growth and the stages of a person's life in Torah, the order inverts. House comes first. Then garments. Then body. And that reversal tells us something profound: the same system that describes levels of affliction also maps the journey of a person maturing in their avodah. Each stage is not just a different location. It is a different relationship to truth.

The House: Private Reality and Bittul

Tzaraas of the house is the most hidden stage. A person notices something — maybe. They are not even sure. And what must they do? They go to the Kohen. They say: I do not know. I need guidance. That is bittul. That is a person admitting they cannot fully evaluate themselves. And halachically, this is critical: until the Kohen declares it tzaraas, it is not tzaraas. A person cannot self-diagnose. They must allow someone else in — into their house, into their private space, into their inner world. Only then can truth be established.

And then something almost shocking happens. Chazal tell us that when the walls are broken, treasure is found. There is a reward. This connects to the level of chinuch — reward-based growth, like training a young child. My cousin once trained his dog using the same method his sister had used to potty-train her children: when they do the right thing, give a small treat. And it worked — until it did not. The dog learned to pretend. To act like it had done what it was supposed to do, just to get the reward. The behavior was there. The intention was not. That is exactly the danger at this stage. External reward without internal change. Action without alignment. That is why the Torah does not allow a person to jump ahead. You do not break the house until the Kohen says so. You do not chase reward. You submit to truth.

The Garments: The Beinoni Level

The next stage is garments. Now it is more visible. Others can begin to see. It is no longer fully private. And because of that, it is addressed earlier.

This is the beinoni level. The person is already working on themselves, already growing. They do not need a reward to motivate them — they are in process. But something is slightly off, visible enough that others might notice even if the person themselves has not fully registered it. Status quo. Mostly functioning, mostly aligned. A patch is removed, the garment is purified, and life continues. The reminder is gentle. No crisis, no exile. Just: look a little closer at what you are presenting to the world. The person is already opening themselves, already allowing others to see and to help.

The Body: Tochacha and the Korban

The final stage is the body. Now everything is revealed. There is no hiding. The person leaves the camp. They call out — not just to others, but to themselves:

טָמֵא טָמֵא יִקְרָא

"Tamei, tamei" (Vayikra 13:45)

Chazal explain: לְהוֹדִיעַ צַעֲרוֹ לָרַבִּים — "To make his suffering known to the many" (Talmud Bavli, Moed Katan 5a). But this is not just a declaration of impurity. It is direct tochacha from Hashem. It is the person saying out loud: I am not aligned. I need to fix this.

And the process that follows is not punishment. It is transformation. Separation. Reflection. Return. When the person comes back, they bring a korban. But a korban is not merely a ritual act. The Ramban at the beginning of Vayikra explains that the word קָרְבָּן is rooted in the language of closeness — קִרְיבָה. And the Maharal in Gevuros Hashem, chapter 8, similarly explains it as an expression of הִתְקָרְבוּת לַה׳, drawing close to Hashem. The entire process of tzaraas was never about pushing a person away. It was about bringing them back.

Hashem revealed what was misaligned. He exposed it. He forced it outward. Why? Because He wants the person back. He wants them to fix it, to return, to come back into the camp, back into their avodah, back into their tafkid. And after teshuvah, after

reflection, after separation, the person returns and says: I am ready. I see what needed to change. I am aligned. And the korban is that moment of reconnection — not just to Hashem, but to who they are supposed to be.

That is the deepest reward. Not the treasure in the walls. Not the external fix. But the ability to return. To stand again before Hashem. To do one's avodah. To live with clarity and purpose. That is why the process exists at all. Because Hashem does not want distance. He wants return. He wants closeness. He wants us back.

Not All Tumah Is the Same

Before we close, there is one more distinction the parsha teaches. At the end of Metzora, the Torah discusses zav, zavah, and other bodily flows. These also create tumah. But Chazal do not attribute them to sin. This is critical: not all tumah is the result of wrongdoing. Sometimes the Torah is teaching process. Cycles. Distance and return. Childbirth itself creates tumah. Life itself creates states of distance that require return. Not every person in a state of tumah is there because they failed. Sometimes the system is simply reminding us: there is always a way back.

Sefiras HaOmer: Building Alignment

We are in the days of Sefiras HaOmer — a time where we are not just counting days, but building ourselves. Each week, each day, we work on different middos. We take what is internal and refine it. In the structure of the sefiros, there is a need for both chesed and gevurah. Chesed without boundaries leads to overflow. Gevurah without clarity leads to restriction. True avodah is when there is alignment — when each middah is in its proper place. Tzaraas is what happens when that alignment breaks, when boundaries blur, when distinctions collapse. Sefiras HaOmer is the process of repairing that — of putting each part of ourselves back into its proper place, of living with clarity.

Returning to the Question

Now we return to Liba Esther's question. Why do we go back to Hashem?

Rav Channen explained simply. A parent does not want to send a child away. A parent wants to bring their child close. The sending is never rejection — it is purposeful. It creates the space for the child to grow into something, so that when they return, the return means something. At the end of our time, Hashem brings us back and asks: what did you do while you were out?

And this is exactly the metzora. Sent out. Declares טָמֵא. Does the work. And returns. The question is the same: what changed? But this is not only about the end of life. It is about every day. We leave. We return. And we answer.

Closing

Tzaraas is not punishment. It is revelation. It is Hashem saying: you are not aligned. Come back.

From house to garments to body. From hidden to visible to fully revealed. From external reward to internal growth to full return.

May we merit to recognize the message early. To live with clarity. To maintain proper distinctions. And to return — each day, and ultimately fully — back to Hashem.

Reflection Questions

• *At the end of each day, do I actually return — or do I just move on to the next thing without accounting for where I have been?*

• *What would it mean to answer Hashem honestly: here is what I did today, here is what I built, here is what I missed?*

• *Where in my life have I been blurring a distinction I know matters — between roles, between people, between what is similar and what is actually the same?*

• *Is my avodah at the level of the house — needing reward to move — or have I grown into the garment level, where the work itself is the motivation?*

• *Is there a place in my life where I have been "outside the camp" — where I know something needs to change but I have not yet made the declaration?*

• *When I imagine standing before Hashem and being asked what I did while I was out — what do I want that answer to be? And what do I need to do today for that answer to be true?*